Base Plot

WARNING: This game deals with sensitive topics such as child abuse, sexual abuse, domestic abuse, mental health, medical malpractice, and suicide.

Set in the year 1934. "Benny" Unutma has *dissociative amnesia and forgets the traumatic events of his life leading up to him killing himself. Currently his soul sits in limbo, unaware of who he is, where he is, or what happened to him. His subconscious speaks to him, guiding him, informing him that he was looking for someone and to follow the shadows. The subconscious does not offer a name and is slightly misleading, Benny asks if he can refer to it as "Mary" (the name of his mother, this will now be how the subconscious Benny is referred to in the notes).

The player will need to travel linearly through 4 total acts (these will be expanded upon on the following pages).
(Start) (CC): Love, Mom (30min) -> Comorbidity: Yours, Truly. (30min) -> (Tx): Forgotten (Again) (20min)-> (DC): Sincerely, Roses (10min) (End)

Each act represents a traumatic event in Benny's life as well as declaring medical terms. The reason for this is in tangent to the name "The Residual Record." This loosely means "the remaining story" but is intentionally ambiguous to be left up to individual perception. The acts(AKA levels) refer to medical terms to suggest "The Residual Record" actually refers to someone's medical record, in which case this translates more so to "the remaining medical document." The reason for the remaining aspect is to suggest that some of that document has been lost as this story is being viewed from Benny's mind which may feel as though things are missing due to suffering from dissociative amnesia.

* Dissociative amnesia is a mental health condition where a person cannot recall important personal or autobiographical information (usually related to a severe traumatic, abusive, or stressful event) which goes far beyond normal forgetfulness.
Note: There are many different types of dissociative amnesia, this is a broad representation and not a claim to any specific experience of this condition.

(CC): Love, Mom

Location: Childhood home
Medical term: Chief Complaint (CC): The primary reason a patient is seeking care.

Plot Significance

This location is Benny's childhood home, his mother(named Mary, however to not cause confusion she will be referred to as Mother from here on) took care of him while dad was not in the picture. Mother would often leave Benny home alone and when she was home she was frequently drunk and verbally abusive to Benny. Although this game has no active threats, the goal is to make the atmosphere very uncomfortable as if there is a threatening force looming around each corner. Information about the house situation would be visible through family portraits on the walls, the front door to the house being agape, being able to speak to Mother through the door, beer bottles around the unkempt home, as well as the puzzles relating to food scarcity and not disrupting Mother in her room after the initial conversation with her. This is the earliest severely traumatic experience in Benny's life that holds a lot of weight to how he went on with life after being "the primary reason a patient is seeking care." This is, to Benny, one of his biggest traumas.

Pretense

The player will start on a black screen, Mary will begin speaking. Mary will communicate that the player is looking for someone, this interaction may look like this (may be changed later):

Mary: "Don't forget. You need to find someone".
Benny(Player): "Who are you? Where am I? Who am I looking for?"
Mary: "Just follow the shadows".
Benny: "Who are you?"
Mary: "I'm here to help. Now wake up".

After this interaction the act name "(CC): Love. Mom" will appear on screen before loading the first act.

Objective

Note: Mechanics and specific puzzles will not be fully planned on this document. This document serves as a structure planning document to explain relevance and context to the world of this game. Specific puzzles/mechanic explanations will be placed on a separate document.

The player will "wake up" in a child's room within the house. The player is free to explore the house from here on out, upon interacting with certain items Benny will have a comment about the item depending on what it is. Benny's comments will mostly consist of objective observations with some confusion. Some items may provoke Benny saying "This looks oddly familiar," but nothing will be fully recognized by Benny during the first act. Most doors within the house will be unlocked, including Mother's room. If the player attempts to enter this room before talking to Mother at the front door (this is the only interval the player will be able to access this room), Benny will speak once the door to the room is interacted with. This line may look like "I feel uncomfortable going in this room". The player can choose to ignore this comment and interact with the door again to fully enter. This room will have no puzzle significance but will have some possible lore to find.

In order to progress to the puzzle stage of this act the player will need to navigate to the agape front door, approaching the door will trigger speaking to Mother before the player can attempt to interact with the door. Mother and Benny will have an uncomfortable exchange while Mother is clearly intoxicated. She states she's going to her room and to not bother her, after this interaction the front door will slam. Following that the player will hear crashing noises followed by crying. A comment to follow the crying will appear on screen. The player will be able to find a small shadow (seemingly of a child) hiding under a cabinet, the shadow will say it's scared and hungry. The player needs to find food within the house for the shadow 3 times, each of which becomes more disturbing, before progressing forward to the next location.

Comorbidity: Yours, Truly.

Location: Romantic Dinner (Previously Love tunnel at a carnival)
Medical term: Comorbidity: A separate, simultaneous illness that coexists alongside a primary condition.

Plot Significance

Benny's romantic relationship trauma is somewhat in tangent to his trauma from home. In his teenage years he went on a date with a woman (referred to as Molly from here on) significantly older than him to a carnival event. They travel through the love tunnel together where she assaults him leaving him confused and scared.

Objective

After being able to leave the previous location the player can travel through the front door walking down a path leading through the carnival into the love tunnel. While traveling to the love tunnel Mary may speak to Benny and this will be where Benny asks to refer to the speaking voice as "Mary." Mary will respond in a slightly dejected manner to say "If that makes you comfortable", before shifting topics and will not comment on this decision from Benny until the end of the game.

Once the player has reached the carnival, a shadow travels with a woman(Molly) who has no face (no characters that can be spoken to truly have a face, including Mother) toward the love tunnel. The carnival appearance is run down, broken, or otherwise disheveled except for the love tunnel that seems to be the only functioning attraction. Certain games along the way to the love tunnel can be interacted with to provide comments from Benny as well as hidden information regarding Molly such as her age, past, and intentions. Entering the love tunnel, Molly will be sitting on a boat that the player will need to enter and begin the ride. A conversation will be had with Molly, Molly will be antagonizing to Benny by insults and saying no one will love him etc.

This conversation may look something like this:
Molly: Oh, miss me already do you?
Benny: I'm sorry? This is my first time here. I'm.. looking for someone.
Molly: Don't play dumb. I know why you're here.
Benny: …
Molly: You can't be serious. You get me all worked up and then just leave me?
Benny: I think you're mistaken ma'am, I'm not sure who you are
Molly: You know what happens when I don't get what I want.
No one will love you if you behave that way.
I'm the only person that will deal with you.
You only have me and you better remember that.

The lights will flicker leaving the player entirely alone in the boat and tunnel. The tunnel appears much more vast and dark than previously. The atmosphere is meant to make the player feel overwhelmingly uncomfortable, alone, and also trapped. There will occasionally be sounds of sobbing or as if there is some sort of fight going on but will never be visible within the darkness.

The objective of this location is to shine light into the tunnel by finding ways to break the exterior of the tunnel to allow outside light in to be able to see the emergency escape. This objective will be given by an observation from Benny such as "It's dark.. Too dark. I need to find a way to see". Light needs to be brought into the tunnel 3 times before the exit is revealed. As the player makes progress Molly will have scripted times to speak/scream at Benny saying various things such as love bombing, threats, flirting, apologizing, etc. Once again, in this location Mary cannot be spoken to. Molly's objective is to not let the player escape and try to manipulate Benny into staying in the darkness. The light fully filling the tunnel will reveal Molly as an old creepy woman in a revealing dress that screams at Benny to leave while the crying shadows are now visible sitting crouched hiding from Molly.

IMPORTANT NOTE: This location will be changed to a romantic dinner setting. Functionally the mechanics are still the same but the location will be rewritten.

(Tx): Forgotten (Again)

Location: Mental asylum
Medical term: Plan (Tx): The prescribed treatment, medications, or follow-up steps.

Plot Significance

In Benny's late teenage years (18-19) after the situation with Molly, he was admitted to a mental asylum which were at the peak of their systemic, ethical, and medical failures at the time. The specific inciting incident to Benny being admitted isn't fully clear or ever told, suggestions can be found that Mother admitted Benny into the asylum. The staff treat their patients horribly, there are too many patients so food and care is scarce. Benny once admitted is not allowed outdoors due to being under surveillance. In this section the player (or Benny) can try to speak with nurses but will continuously be ignored. Mary will be the only one to speak with Benny during this section. In some sections of the hospital a park outside can be seen through the windows, Benny will frequently make comments about finding it beautiful and wanting to touch the flowers but being unable to. This will be the most uncomfortable section of the game. The puzzle in this section is Benny taking "necessary" medications, in reality these medications are not necessary and result in Benny's death due to mistreatment of his mental disorders.

Objective

The objective is to be able to escape the asylum, the way this is achieved is by finding the correct medications Benny needs. The player will need to walk through the asylum reading doctor notes and finding keys to get into locked areas for records and medications. During this time information of Benny's past will be revealed through various doctor's notes of different dates. This will reveal the connection between the previous locations and an insight into Benny's psyche. An admission note can also be found that reveals "Mary Unutma" (Mother) is the one that admitted Benny into the asylum. Benny will begin questioning Mary about the situation, Mary will only respond to certain questions and leave Benny to explore.

(DC): Sincerely, Roses

Location: Park filled with flowers
Medical term: Discontinue (DC): When a clinician plans to stop or reduce a medical or treatment plan.

Plot Significance

This act is the finale, it is shorter than all previous acts and will not actually include any puzzles. The player at this point will have been given enough information to start piecing together the fact that the previous acts are traumatic events of Benny's past, and that the person the player is looking for is the character they are playing. The end is mostly to tie everything together and explain it all to the player.

Objective

The previous act will end with the player being able to find an exit to the asylum that leads into a park filled with flowers. The player can travel on a path through the flowers being the only direction the player can go. Mary will continuously speak about Benny's condition including the fact that Mary is his subconscious as the player keeps walking. The player will eventually reach a gurney with a shadow on it, there would be ambulance sirens in the background getting louder. Interacting with the laying down shadow will make Mary respond with "I hope you can rest now that you remember", ending the game and sending the player to the end credits.